ZIMBABWE ELECTORAL COMMISSION

REPORT ON THE GURUVE RDC WARD 13, CHEGUTU RDC WARD 3 AND NORTON TOWN COUNCIL WARD 3 LOCAL AUTHORITY BY-ELECTIONS

HELD ON

08 MARCH 2025

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

1. The Zimbabwe Electoral Commission (ZEC) is an Election Management Body (EMB) established in terms of Section 238 of the Constitution of Zimbabwe.
2. Its functions are provided for in *Section 239* of the said Constitution.
3. Following the notification of the local authority vacancies which arose in Guruve RDC Ward 14, Chegutu RDC Ward 3 and Norton Town Council Ward 3, the Commission issued a **ZEC Notice dated 16 January 2025** calling for by-elections to be held on 08 March 2025.
4. T*he Commission submitted a budget totalling ZiG **4 930 800.00** for the by-elections and only ZiG**3 343 000.00*** was received**. The amount was not sufficient to cover election allowances for deployed staff.**
5. The Commission conducted voter education programmes for the sitting of nomination courts and polling between 22 January 2025 and 1 March 2025. The messages centred on the cause of the by-elections, qualifications for candidates and on how to vote.
6. The Nomination Courts to receive nomination papers for candidates to stand for election for, Guruve RDC Ward 14, Chegutu RDC Ward 3 and Norton Town Council Ward 3 sat on 06 February 2025. The following candidates were nominated at the close of sitting of the court: -

NOMINATED CANDIDATES

	Local Authority	Ward	Candidate	Sex	Sponsoring Party
1	Chegutu RDC	3	Makofi Mahwinei	M	ZANU PF
			Murombedzi Stabile	F	INDEPENDENT
			Sibanda Tawanda	M	INDEPENDENT
2	Norton Town Council	3	Munyeveri Walter	M	INDEPENDENT
			Paradzai Preston Tanatswa	M	INDEPENDENT
			Tsomondo Wilson Charamba	M	ZANU PF

3	Guruve RDC	14	Maguduru Thompson	M	ZANU PF

6.1 Following the successful conduct of the Nomination Courts, ***Maguduru Thompson*** *of* ***ZANU PF*** party, was duly declared elected councillor for ***Guruve RDC Ward 14*** unopposed as no other nomination papers were received for his ward at the close of same.

6.2 The High Court under Case Number HCH1052/25 issued an order on 08 March 2025 which disqualified Munyeveri Walter from contesting in the Norton Town Council Ward 3 by-elections citing that he was not a resident of the Ward where elections were conducted.

7. A total of five thousand four hundred (5 400) ballot papers were printed for the local authority by-elections. This information was publicised in terms of the law in the print media on 13 February 2025.

8. The Commission established ten (10) polling stations for voting purposes and these were also publicised in terms of the law.

9 The Commission used its own fleet of vehicles during the by-elections.

10. The training of electoral officers of different categories was conducted from 26 February to 04 March 2025.

11. Applications for the accreditation of observers were received and processed on time.

12. The by-elections were held on 08 March 2025 and results were declared on the same day.

13. Below is a Schedule of Local Authority candidates that were declared winners after the polls:

Candidates Elected Following Poll

Local Authority	Ward	Winner	Sex	Party
Chegutu RDC	3	Sibanda Tawanda	M	INDEPENDENT
Norton Town Council	3	Tsomondo Wilson	M	ZANU PF

14. The 08 March 2025 by-elections were held under peaceful conditions and no reports of politically motivated disturbances were received by the Commission.

PART I

1.0 THE ZIMBABWE ELECTORAL COMMISSION

1.1 Composition

The Zimbabwe Electoral Commission (ZEC) is an Election Management Body (EMB) established in terms of the Section 238 of the Constitution of Zimbabwe.

It is composed of a Chairperson appointed by the President after consultation with the Judicial Service Commission and the Committee on Standing Rules and Orders and eight other members appointed by the President from a list of not fewer than twelve nominees submitted by the Committee on Standing Rules and Orders.

At the time of the by-elections, the Commission consisted of a full board of nine members as follows:

1	Honourable Mrs Justice Priscilla Makanyara Chigumba		Chairperson
2	Ambassador Rodney Simukai Kiwa	-	Deputy Chairperson
3	Mr Jasper Mangwana	-	Commissioner
4	Mrs Abigail Millicent Mohadi- Ambrose	-	Commissioner
5	Mr Shepherd Manhivi	-	Commissioner
6	Ms Catherine Mpofu	-	Commissioner
7	Mrs Rosewita Murutare	-	Commissioner
8	Dr Janet Mbetu Nzvenga	-	Commissioner
9	Dr Kudzai Shava	-	Commissioner

1.2 Functions of the Commission

The functions of the Zimbabwe Electoral Commission are provided for in Section 239 of the Constitution as follows:

a. to prepare for, conduct and supervise –

(i) elections to the office of President and to Parliament;

(ii) elections to provincial and metropolitan councils and the governing bodies of local authorities;

(iii) elections of Members of the National Council of Chiefs established by section 285; and

(iv) referendums;

and to ensure that those elections and referendums are conducted efficiently, freely, fairly, transparently and in accordance with the law,

b. to supervise elections of the President of the Senate and the Speaker and to ensure that these elections are conducted efficiently and in accordance with the law;

c. to register voters;

d. to compile voters' rolls and registers,

e. to ensure the proper custody and maintenance of voters rolls and registers;

f. to delimit constituencies, wards and other electoral boundaries;

g. to design, print and distribute ballot papers, approve the form of and procure ballot boxes, and establish and operate polling centres;

h. to conduct and supervise voter education;

i. to accredit observers of elections and referendums;

j. to give instructions to persons in the employment of the State or of a local authority for the purpose of ensuring the efficient, free, fair, proper and transparent conduct of any election or referendum; and

k. to receive and consider complaints from the public and to take such action in regard to the complaints as it considers appropriate.

1.3 Additional Functions

The Electoral Act [*Chapter 2:13*] in Section 5 thereof provides for additional functions and powers of the Commission as follows:

a. undertaking and promoting research into electoral matters

b. developing expertise and the use of technology in regard to the electoral processes; and

c. promoting co-operation between Government, political parties and civil society in regard to elections; and

d. keeping the public informed about -

   i. the times and places where persons can register as voters and the progress of the voter registration exercise; and

   ii. the delimitation of wards, constituencies and other electoral boundaries, and

   iii. the location and boundaries of polling stations and when they are open for inspection; and

   iv. voters roll and the times and places at which they are open for inspection; and

   v. political parties and candidates contesting every election and;

   vi. voting; and

   vii. generally, all matters relating to the Commission's work and the electoral process; and

(d1) ensuring that gender is mainstreamed into electoral processes; and

(e) making recommendations to Parliament on appropriate ways to provide public financing for political parties.

PART II

2.0 BUDGET

T*he Commission submitted a budget totalling ZiG* ***4 930 800.00*** *for the by-elections and only ZiG****3 343 000.00*** was received. The amount was not sufficient to cover election allowances for deployed staff.

PART III

3.0 PREPARATIONS FOR THE BY-ELECTIONS

3.1 ZEC Notice dated 16 January 2025

Following the receipt of notification of the vacancies that had arisen in Guruve RDC Ward 14, Chegutu RDC Ward 3, and Norton Town Council Ward 3, the Commission issued a **ZEC Notice dated 16 January 2025** calling for by-elections to be held on 08 March 2025. The seats became vacant by reason of death of councillors who were duly elected in the 2023 Harmonised Elections. The Commission duly prepared for the by-elections in the Wards concerned.

3.2 Voter Education

The Commission conducted pre-nomination and pre-polling voter education for the said by-elections between the 22nd and 26th of January 2025 and 25th of February and 1st of March 2025 respectively. The key messages for the pre-nomination phase centred on what had caused the by-elections and who qualified to be a candidate in the elections. The pre-polling emphasized on preparing the electorate on knowing the contesting candidates, the correct documentation to carry, the polling date and time, the voting process and how to cast a vote, assisted and redirected voters and encouraging the electorate to go and vote.

The voter education team used various methodologies to educate the electorate such as the door-to-door visits, interaction with individuals and addressing of gatherings, use of posters and distribution of pamphlets and flyers.

3.3 Nomination Court Results

The Nomination Courts to receive nomination papers for candidates to stand for election as councillors sat on 06 February 2025. At the close of the Nomination Courts, the following candidates successfully lodged their papers.

	Local Authority	Ward	Candidate	Sex	Sponsoring Party
1	Chegutu RDC	3	Makofi Mahwinei	M	ZANU PF
			Murombedzi Stabile	F	INDEPENDENT
			Sibanda Tawanda	M	INDEPENDENT

2	Norton Town Council	3	Munyeveri Walter	M	INDEPENDENT
			Paradzai Preston Tanatswa	M	INDEPENDENT
			Tsomondo Wilson Charamba	M	ZANU PF
3	Guruve RDC	14	Maguduru Thompson	M	ZANU PF

3.4 Following the successful conduct of the Nomination Courts, ***Maguduru Thompson*** *of* ***ZANU PF*** party, was duly declared elected councillor for ***Guruve RDC Ward 14*** unopposed as no other nomination papers were received at the close of same.

3.5 The High Court under Case Number HCH1052/25 issued an order on 08 March 2025 which disqualified Munyeveri Walter from contesting in the by-elections citing that he was not a resident of the Ward where elections were conducted.

3.6 Voter Registration

For the by-election concerned there was no voter registration prior to the sitting of the Nomination Courts considering that according to Section 121A (3) of the Electoral Act, in local authority by-elections, the closure of the voters' roll occurs on the day a vacancy arises.

3.7 Provision of Voters' rolls

The contesting candidates were issued with copies of voters' roll for their respective wards. An analysable electronic voters' roll was placed at respective provincial, district and ward centres for access by the public.

3.8 Multiparty Liaison Committee Meetings

An average of three (3) Multiparty committee meetings were held in the districts and wards where by-elections were conducted. The meetings were successful and all outstanding issues concerning the conduct of the by-elections were resolved.

3.9 Polling Stations

A total of ten (10) polling stations were established in the wards that had by-elections. Below is a breakdown of the Polling Stations.:

Breakdown of Polling Stations for 8 March 2025 By-elections

Ser	Province	District	Local Authority	Ward	No. of Polling Stations
1	Mash West	Chegutu	Chegutu RDC	Ward 3	**5**
2	Mash West	Chegutu	Norton Town Council	Ward 3	**5**
3	**Total**				**10**

3.10 Ballot Paper Printing

A total of five thousand four hundred **(5 400)** ballot papers were printed for the 08 March 2025 by-elections by the Printing and Minting Company of Zimbabwe (PMCZ). This information was publicised in terms of the law.

3.11 Transport

The Commission used its own vehicle fleet for the by-elections. Each polling station was allocated a vehicle resulting in smooth deployment of staff, transmission of results and decamping.

3.12 Recruitment, Training and Deployment of Electoral Officers

Personnel to conduct the by-elections were drawn from the host Province i.e. Mashonaland West and Harare Metropolitan province, the Civil Service Commission and Local Authorities where there were by-elections. The recruitment of Ward Elections Officers and their Deputies was done on time and same were trained between 26 and 27 February 2025. The training of all electoral officials was conducted between 01 and 04 March 2025.

Deployment of electoral officers took place prior to their training sessions. Training for polling officers was done at polling station level. The Zimbabwe Republic Police (ZRP) officers were deployed alongside electoral staff to provide security.

Setting up of polling stations and rehearsals were done a day before poll.

3.13Accreditation of Observers and Media Personnel

The accreditation of observers for the by-election was conducted between 17 January and 08 March 2025.

PART IV

4.0 CONDUCT OF ELECTION – POLLING

4.1 Polling

Polling took place on 8 March 2025 commencing from 0700 hours and ending at 1900 hours for Ward 3 of Chegutu RDC. Polling stations in Ward 3 of Norton Town Council opened at 1000 hrs and closed at 2300 hrs. The delay was occasioned by the High Court ruling in Case HCH1052/25 which nullified the candidature of the independent candidate, Walter Munyeveri. This resulted in the reprinting and redistribution of ballot papers excluding Walter Munyeveri. The judgement was given on the eve of the election. Due regard was given to the provision that no voter in the queue of persons waiting to vote as at closing time would be turned away.

Every polling station was staffed by electoral officers as well as election agents, observers and police details that provided security and performed other duties as provided by the law.

Only one (1) distinctly marked ballot box for the Ward by-election concerned was set up in each polling station.

4.2 Assisted Voters

The below table shows the number by gender of persons assisted in the Wards during the by-elections.

Province	**Assisted Voters**		**Total**
	Female	Male	
Ward 3 Chegutu RDC	47	18	65
Ward 3 Norton Town Council	4	2	6
Total	**51**	**20**	**71**

The illiterate, the elderly and the visually impaired voters who were not able to vote without assistance were assisted by persons of their choice in line with the law. A person who did not bring an assistant was assisted by the Presiding Officer in the presence of two other officers and the police officer on duty.

4.3 Turned Away Voters

The two wards had a total of ninety-three (93) turned away voters broken down as follows;

Province	Turned Away Voters		Total
	Female	Male	
Chegutu RDC Ward 3	27	22	49
Norton Town Council Ward 3	19	25	44
Total	**46**	**47**	**93**

The reasons for turning away voters were non-possession of identity cards and not appearing on the voters' roll among others.

4.4 Verification and Counting

The counting of the votes was preceded by the verification of ballots which process was administered at polling station level by the presiding officers in the presence of candidates and their election agents present. The verification and counting of polling station results was completed on 08 March 2025 for Chegutu RDC Ward 3 and 9 March 2025 for Norton Town Council Ward 3 for reasons already stated above.

4.5 Results of Poll

The Ward Elections Officers declared the results of the poll at the respective ward collation centres. The polling station results were posted outside the polling stations and the collated results at the ward collation centres.

The summary of the results for the by-elections was as follows:

Chegutu RDC	3	Makofi Mahwinei	M	ZANU PF	476	
		Murombedzi Stabile	F	INDEPENDENT	88	
		Sibanda Tawanda	***M***	***INDEPENDENT***	***613***	***Winner***
				Rejected Votes	10	
				Total	1187	
				Voter Population	2670	
				% Turn-Out	**44.5**	

Chegutu RDC Ward 3 had a voter population of 2670 and only 1187 voters cast their vote on 08 March 2025. This indicates that the voter turnout was low as it stood at 44.5%

Norton Town Council	3	Paradzayi Preston Tanatswa	M	INDEPENDENT	222	
		Tsomondo Wilson Charamba	**M**	**ZANU PF**	**233**	***Winner***
				Rejected Votes	3	
				Total	458	
				Voter Population	2373	
				% Turn-Out	**19.3**	

Norton Council Ward 3 had a voter population of 2373 and only 458 voters cast their vote on 08 March 2025.This indicates that the voter turnout was low as it stood at 19.3%

4.6 The Environment

The elections were held under calm and peaceful conditions and the Commission did not receive any report on politically motivated incidents.

PART V

5.0 OBSERVATIONS, RECOMMENDATIONS AND CONCLUSION

The Commission made an observation and a recommendation as presented below.

5.1 Electoral Courts

The decision to disqualify an aspiring candidate for Norton Town Council Ward 3 from contesting in the 08 March 2025 was done in the early hours of the polling day. This caused delay in opening of the polling stations as the ballots had to be reprinted without the candidate's name.

5.2 Recommendation

Parliament should consider coming up with a law that provides the cut -off date for resolving electoral matters prior to the polling day.

5.3 Conclusion

Generally, the 08 March 2025 by-elections were conducted in a peaceful manner. The Commission consulted and worked in collaboration with its stakeholders throughout the election period ensuring that the process was inclusive and transparent.

The Commission is satisfied that the 08 March 2025 by-elections were conducted in a manner and under conditions that allowed voters to freely express their will.

Signed:  Date: 25 July 2025

Mrs Justice Priscilla Makanyara Chigumba

ZEC Chairperson